

It's Normal to Talk about Money

I recently spoke to a couple who constantly argue over their finances. I asked them, "When do you just *talk* about money?" They both looked at each other and laughed.

"We talk about it when we fight," the wife said.

"No other time?"

"No," the husband said, confused. "What, like, do we have a money meeting with an agenda? That would be weird."

You know what I think is weird? Fighting for the next forty years of your relationship because you never created a joint vision together. (And besides, who doesn't love the special moment of opening your agenda and seeing an exquisitely detailed document with every relevant piece of information perfectly laid out, including a clickable table of contents and key decisions listed on top? Okay, don't worry, it can be a bit more casual.)

Deep down, many of us believe that those moments of high tension and drama are the only times to have these conversations. You live your life, and then when a financial issue sparks an argument, you deal with it. Think about it: Did you ever see your parents pull out a monthly agenda and calmly discuss finances? The people who believe "money = fighting" almost always grew up seeing their parents, well, fight about money.

In my work with couples, I show them that money can be a normal topic to discuss *before* there's an argument. I encourage them to set up an hour every month to talk about what's on their minds, to offer each other at least one positive compliment about their partner's money management, and to plan proactively for the next month's financial decisions.

You decide what works for you. If other people think it's weird, who cares?